

interface is quite easy to navigate and helps you pick the right template for an invoice, fax or presentation. You can open a new document or template, browse through folders to pick a template, preview template details and layout and open existing documents from your 'My Documents' folder right from this one navigation window.

Autopilot in StarOffice is the equivalent of the 'Template Wizard' in Office. It can be found in the File menu of all StarOffice applications. Autopilot isn't as advanced as the wizards in Office but runs you through the basic steps of customising templates the way you want them.

Database integration: StarOffice has support for internal (StarOffice 5.2) as well as external data sources such as Netscape, Mozilla or Windows System Address book. They can be integrated into StarOffice at the time of installation or manually through Autopilot > Address Data Source. This makes mailing out documents to multiple recipients (or a mail merge) a breeze.

Writing off Word

The interface of Star Writer, the word processor, does feel a little different from Word but the most commonly used functions in Word are available here as well.

Writer easily imports and handles different file formats

from different versions of Word as well as text documents for Macintosh and Unix without losing out on much of the text formatting. It's only while importing StarOffice documents into Word that you might lose some of the formatting. To save documents in HTML, go to File > Send > Create HTML document.

Formatting text: If you're looking for the familiar Format menu options as in Word, you'll find them all organised quite neatly in StarOffice.

Format >Page takes care of your page size, margins and page background. For the background you can either choose solid colours, images from the StarOffice clip gallery or your own background.

You can add and set the size (in centimetres) and the style of different page elements such as headers and footers, borders, columns and footnotes. This dialog has a small page preview option that gives you a glimpse of how these elements are going to look against the page.

Backgrounds, borders and shadowing effects can be set for Headers and Footers. The shadowing option for the page and the Header/

Footer borders is especially neat as you can set the distance to determine the shadowing effect.

You can either format footnotes while formatting a page or insert it through Insert > Footnote. You can set the footnote area, the separator line that separates the footnote from the document and number the footnotes.

Format > Character is where you set fonts, font size and font effects such as embossing and font position (subscript, superscript) while Format > Paragraph takes care of formatting blocks of text—alignment, paragraph indents and spacing, hyphenation, border and background for paragraphs, drop caps, etc.

'Bullets and numbering' has some pretty good styles. The standard bullets are the same but there are more options for graphical bullets in Writer. The options to align and control the spacing of the bullets are especially good.

The StarOffice Stylist, a window containing a library of styles, is present across all applications

and provides another easy way to format text. All you need to do is select the text and double-click on the style in the window to apply it.

If you don't want to manually format text, there's always Autoformat and Autocorrect, both in the same dialog and with similar functionality as Word.

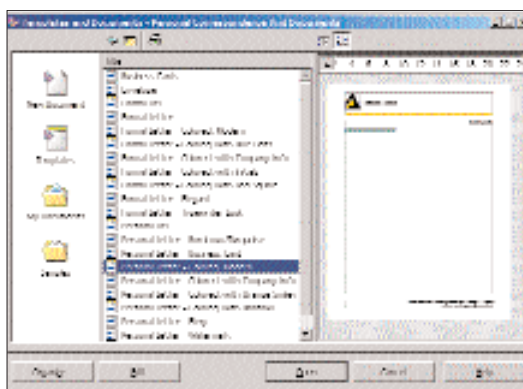
Tools consists of a spell checker, thesaurus, line numbering and macros. The Insert menu has the same elements as Word—Find and Replace, Comments, Bookmarks, Footnotes, Captions, Cross-reference and Hyperlinks. In addition you can also insert charts, diagrams and images. You can insert special characters and symbols into the text through Insert > Special Characters.

The comment feature isn't as good as in Word. It lets you insert a note at the cursor position, but the note isn't visible on a mouse over. You have to double-click on the note indication for the note to pop up.

Star Writer has a clip gallery with fairly good images. You can insert images into the document from a file or the StarOffice clip gallery.

Auto abstract is a neat feature packed into Writer that extracts the title, summary and sub-headings of a long document and saves it to a new document.

You can create a small table in Writer by selecting **Insert > Table**, selecting the number of rows and columns and entering the data. Alternatively, you can define table attributes at **Tools >**



StarOffice has a neat template management feature

Say it with XML

There's been a lot of talk from Sun about a new XML-based file format for documents in StarOffice 6.0 and the increased functionality that it would bring to its users. So what's this all about?

This means that parts of an Office document such as the content, layout and meta information are stored as separate XML streams along with embedded graphics and objects contained in the document. This is done so that they can be read, interpreted and modified independently of each other. This XML format is commonly used across all StarOffice documents, whether it's a spreadsheet or word processor.

How does this help the user? Well, for starters, it will ensure greater compatibility and interoperability of StarOffice file formats with other operating systems as well as with newer versions. With XML, the recipient of a StarOffice document will not be required to have StarOffice installed to view it.

XML also helps in document archiving and preserves the longevity of the document. Being a text-based and human readable format, it allows files to be read even if the original application or the OS that it ran on is not available anymore.

With the XML file format, the user can inspect the content of files being sent or received through the meta information, which is stored as plain text in the Windows Explorer context menu. So the next time you receive a suspicious attachment, you know what to do!